

# Chicago Tribune



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## Labor strife spilling off docks into City Hall

Political implications for mayor as 2 unions fight to represent stevedores

By Talia Soglin  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

At the mouth of the Calumet River on Chicago's industrial Southeast Side, workers load steel, sugar and lumber off and onto ships.

The port is the center of Chicago's maritime economy. But labor strife here is spilling off of the docks and into City Hall, with political implications for Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson, himself a former labor organizer who is expected to run for reelection in less than a year.

Two unions are fighting over who should represent the dozens of stevedores who work for QSL America, a private company that operates at the publicly owned port.

For more than a year, some QSL workers have been on strike with the International Union of Operating Engineers Local 150. But others are still at work, laboring under a new collective bargaining agreement with another labor organization, the International Longshoremen's Association. QSL agreed to recognize the ILA as the dockworkers' union representative last year, after the Operating Engineers' strike began, setting off a battle between the labor groups that is under review by federal regulators at the National Labor Relations Board.

In early June, Johnson met with workers who support the ILA and took a photo with them. The episode prompted accusations of hypocrisy from Local 150, which views the ILA-affiliated workers as strike-breakers and accused Johnson of taking sides.

Johnson is no political ally of the Operating Engineers, who backed Paul Vallas against him in the 2023 mayoral runoff. Local 150's president chairs political committees that have poured money into the campaign of Illinois Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias, a likely 2027 mayoral challenger.

"Mayor Johnson built his public image on the language of solidarity and worker justice, but when working people at Chicago's ports needed that solidarity most, he chose to take a meeting with the very people undermining them and then posed smiling in a photo with longshoremen and workers crossing the picket line," Local 150 spokesperson Kristine Kavanagh said in a statement in June.

The ILA denies that the workers who support them are scabs, saying they are longtime port workers who chose the ILA to represent them. In

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## Ghosts of Kaskaskia

In the first capital of Illinois, all that's left is a church and the congregation keeping it alive



**Above:** An aerial view of Kaskaskia from May 23 shows Immaculate Conception Church, which was founded as a mission by Jacques Marquette in 1675. **At top:** An annual fish fry cookout gathering of family and friends in Kaskaskia on May 23 was a memorial this year to Robby Ray Davis.

E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

By Andrew Carter  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The congregation started to arrive at the usual time, about half an hour before Mass on a recent Saturday afternoon, the old church slowly filling with the descendants and caretakers of a place of great serenity but also great loss. It is a place, these days, that is mostly empty. Desolate. Nature has reclaimed Kaskaskia, the site of Illinois' founding and its first capital, one flood at a time.

Usually, the town's namesake island, far down in downstate Illinois, is quiet enough to hear the hum of the barges droning along the Mississippi River. It is quiet enough that the silence, itself, is a kind of noise. It is the only part of Illinois west of the Mississippi, a geographical oddity that reflects the current's power and unpredictability. The river gave the place life before taking it back.

The history in Kaskaskia is as rich as the soil that attracted settlers in the first place and made it, for a time, Illinois' most important place. There is a Liberty Bell, a gift from King Louis XV of France, that predates the larger and more famous one in Philadelphia, and there's an American story that predates America's founding 250 years ago. There's not much of anything else, aside from the ghosts and the church, its survival a testament to the people who keep it going.

The Immaculate Conception Chapel, a brick Catholic church with a steep spire that has served as a beacon in rising waters, is not dissimilar to the land where it sits. Both exist

See **KASKASKIA** on Page A14

### AMERICA 250



STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

## Celebrating America

Glenna Broderick, right, and Joie Allen, center, along with other circus performers, delight the crowd at Elgin's Fourth of July parade on Saturday. Crowds fanned out across the region to celebrate the holiday with fireworks, parades and community. **Chicagoland**, Page A3

**In Nation & World:** U.S. celebrates from sea to shining sea. **Page B5**

**In Arts & Entertainment:** A ride on the Freedom Truck.

## 'SENSE OF PEACE'

Archdiocese cemetery unveils memorial for suicide loss survivors, the first Catholic tribute of its kind in the nation

By Angie Leventis Lourgos  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

On the seventh anniversary of his death, Bridget Biddinger visited the grave of her brother at Queen of Heaven Catholic Cemetery in Hillside to honor his memory, as she has every year since he died by suicide on June 26, 2019.

Yet when she approached his final resting place, the 37-year-old from Plainfield noticed a crowd forming around a garden

and prominent sculpture on the cemetery grounds that she had never seen there before.

"I don't recognize that," Biddinger thought. "That's new."

She was stunned to learn that, in an uncanny coincidence, Catholic Cemeteries of the Archdiocese of Chicago was hosting a prayer service and dedication of a memorial shrine commemorating lives lost to suicide as well as the loved ones who grieve them.

It is the first memorial of its kind erected by an archdiocese at

a Catholic cemetery in the United States and serves as a physical testament to the church's evolution on the matter of suicide.

Historically, the Catholic Church had denied religious funerals inside houses of worship as well as traditional burials for those who died in this way.

Yet Catholicism — along with much of the rest of society — now offers a much more nuanced and compassionate stance, including

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### ARTS & ENTERTAINMENT

#### Cubs in pop culture

How a painting helped solidify a perception about the Cubs as "lovable losers" that has stuck with them ever since, regardless of the standings.



### SPORTS

#### Reaching fever pitch

If you don't have World Cup fever after watching Argentina play Cape Verde, you should get a red card, plus other sports takeaways from Paul Sullivan.

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